

Humans *through* time

If you are reading this, you must be a human. Humans are the only species that has developed written language. It is one of many things we do that make us unique, along with speaking and making plans, for example. This is all thanks to millions of years of gradual changes, or evolution.



Chimpanzees belong in our family tree.

Mammals evolve

The earliest mammals were small creatures that emerged from reptile ancestors. When a large meteorite hit the Earth, it ended the reign of the dinosaurs and left room for mammals to evolve.

Species split

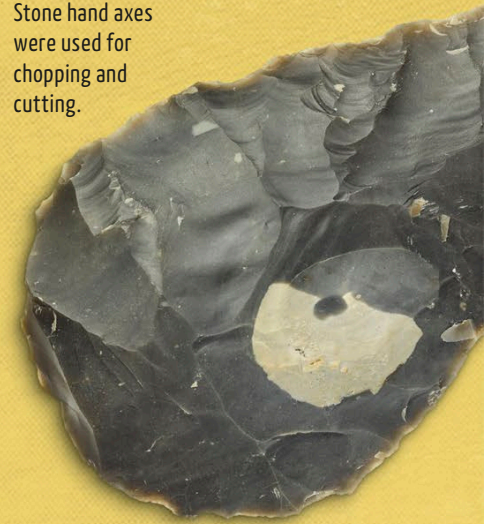
Human and chimpanzee ancestors gradually began splitting into different species.

While the ancestors of chimpanzees lived in trees and used their arms and legs to walk, our closest ancestors started to live on the ground.

Stone tools

Early humans began using their hands to make simple stone tools to chop up meat and plants. It was the beginning of the time period we call “the Stone Age.”

Stone hand axes were used for chopping and cutting.



First in the family

At this time, there lived an animal who looked similar to the orangutans and chimpanzees of today. It is considered to be one of the first members of the family tree that includes humans.

65
mya

mya = million years ago
kya = thousand years ago



12
mya

Our entire family is called the Hominidae, or great apes.

Our ancestors began spending more time on the ground.



10
mya



3.5
mya

By this time, our ancestors stood upright and walked using only their legs.